



Above *Locro de papa* – literally, “potato stew” – may be served smooth or with potato chunks. *Achiote* (annatto) seeds impart a golden glow

Left The volcanic peak of Mount Cayambe looms over Quito, the world’s second-highest capital city



Above A vendor dishes up fried potatoes at the Thursday Saquisilí market in Cotopaxi, south of Quito, one of the largest and busiest in Ecuador

What Else to Eat

A revelation for many, **hornado** might well change the way you regard roast pork. Slow-cooked, succulent, and tender, served with **ají** hot sauce or chopped red onions, potato patties, and fried corn, it’s a must. The Plaza Grande Hotel in Quito serves a superb suckling pig version. A meal is not a meal in the highlands without a soup appetizer. Look for one with **quinoa**, another Andean wonder-ingredient. Hacienda Zuleta (www.zuleta.com) serves delicious soups made from organic ingredients. To warm the cockles on a cold Andean night, a swig of **canelazo** hits the spot. It’s a hot toddy, usually made with naranjilla fruit and local liquor and spiced with cinnamon.

The Best Places to Eat Locro de Papa

Hacienda San Agustín de Callo expensive

There’s no better place to enjoy smooth, delicious, warming *locro de papa* than in the Inca-walled dining room of Hacienda San Agustín, in the shadow of the picture-postcard Cotopaxi volcano. The hacienda’s walls are thought to have been part of an Incan temple, but even without them, this would be a fine place to dine. Its style is country-home-turned-inn, with individually painted rooms with quirky touches ringing a flower-filled central courtyard and fireplaces keeping the chill at bay at night. Service is personalized and, if you’re staying here too, the living room with its comfy sofas and books soon feels like it could be your own.

The *locro* is rich and cheesy, topped with perfectly ripe avocados and with fresh, piquant *ají* sauce on the side for those who like a little zip in their soup. Also on the menu are quinoa soup and croquettes, *llapingachos* (potato cakes) with guacamole, and *fritada* of fried pork in cumin, and all the vegetables are harvested from its own gardens. Desserts are a treat too – guaranteed to have you waddling off to a nearby sofa or hammock for a well-deserved siesta.

Lasso, Cotopaxi Province; open 1–3 PM daily (reservations advisable); www.incahacienda.com

In Quito

The list of establishments serving *locro* is as long as the list of its variants, but in Quito, **La Chozo** in the La Floresta neighborhood (www.lachozaec.com; *moderate*) is regarded by many as the best. It serves lots more fine traditional Ecuadorian dishes as well, such as *hornado* roast pork (see What Else to Eat, *left*), goat stew, soups, and ceviche.

Also in the Ecuadorian Andes

In the north, **Hacienda Zuleta** (www.zuleta.com; *expensive*) serves delicious soups made from organic ingredients; **Hacienda Cusín** (see Where to Stay) and historic **Hacienda Pinsaqui** (www.haciendapinsaqui.com; *expensive*) near Otavalo are also good options. South of Quito, **Estrella de Chimborazo** (www.expediciones-andinas.com; *inexpensive*) is a high-altitude mountain lodge with a spectacular setting beneath the Chimborazo volcano, while **Hostería Abraspungo** near Riobamba (www.haciendaabrapungo.com; *moderate*) has a nice rustic feel. In the southern highlands, try the **Posada Ingapirca** (www.grupo-santaana.net; *moderate*) close to the Inca ruins of the same name. In Ecuador’s third-largest city, pretty Cuenca, **Hotel Santa Lucía** (www.santaluciahotel.com; *expensive*), **Mansión Alcázar** (www.mansionalcazar.com; *expensive*) and the cheerful **Raymipampa** (+593 7 283 4159; *inexpensive*) shouldn’t disappoint.